

# Afternoon Discoveries: October 3, 2026

Speculative, Hybrid, Experimental, Short & Flash Fiction



AMONG THE LETTERS

OCT 03, 2026



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**Speculative, Hybrid,  
Experimental, Short, & Flash  
Fiction**

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*Some stories need an entire world, but others just need a single detail and enough room for us to realize what it changes.*

*Today's shelf moves between both kinds. An artist becomes an orange, a spy struggles to keep his face attached, a question refuses to stay simple, and a magic sword has apparently come with instructions.*

*Elsewhere the strange thing is quieter. A mother watches her daughter grow away from her. Two people disagree about what eternity should mean, and a car crash arrives after another kind of impact has already happened.*

**All links in today's edition were checked against the linked publication, magazine, or archive page on October 3, 2026.**

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## Featured Discovery

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### The Raspberry Manifesto of Professor Warana - Adam-Troy Castro

Something extraordinary has happened to the celebrated artist Dejuik... He has become an orange.

Adam-Troy Castro treats it almost as calmly as the people surrounding it cannot. Explanation quickly gives way to interpretation as the world tries to decide whether Dejuik's transformation is art, tragedy, breakthrough, message, or something else entirely.

The fun is in watching meaning accumulate around something that resists being made sensible. The stranger the event remains the more urgently everyone seems to need a language for it.

Read “The Raspberry Manifesto of Professor Warana” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

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## The Discovery Desk

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### **A Face Slipped Off Its Skull - Ashlee Lhamon**

A compromised operative reaches Grand Central Station bleeding through his coat and trying to look ordinary. The problem is larger than the failed drop. His body is beginning to come apart.

Ashlee Lhamon folds espionage into body horror without losing the clipped pressure of noir. Names, faces, passports, and bodies all become temporary things, which is particularly unsettling for a man whose survival already depends on becoming whoever the next piece of paper says he is.

Read “A Face Slipped Off Its Skull” at [Flash Fiction Online](#)

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### **A Face Slipped Off Its Skull - Ashlee Lhamon**

A spy reaches Grand Central Station after a compromised drop. He is bleeding through his coat and trying very hard to look normal while his body is beginning to come apart.

Names and faces are already temporary things in his line of work. Lhamon makes that much more literal in a story that mixes espionage with body horror and keeps moving before the situation has much chance to settle.

[Read "A Face Slipped Off Its Skull" at Flash Fiction Online](#)

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## **Sixty-One Seconds - Martin Cahill**

Remember the recharge time: a minute and one.

That is how long the narrator needs to survive before another microjump becomes possible. Each jump opens onto another reality, another version of a life, and another chance to keep moving.

Martin Cahill fits an unusual amount into those short bursts. The worlds change quickly, but one person keeps appearing through them.

[Read "Sixty-One Seconds" at hexliterary](#)

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## **The Girls - Patricia Q. Bidar**

Bea is checking on her three hens while thinking about her daughter Polly. Polly is home from college and increasingly aware of how closely her mother watches her. Bea knows some of that worry is pushing her daughter away, but knowing and stopping are different things.

The hens give Bea something smaller and simpler to care for while the relationship inside the house becomes harder to manage.

[Read "The Girls" at Fractured Lit](#)

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## Crash - Mathieu Parsy

Mathieu Parsy's microfiction stays inside the strange clarity that can follow an accident while another loss begins surfacing underneath it. A phone, an unfinished message, and the person waiting on the other end are enough to carry most of the story.

Read "Crash" at Fractured Lit

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*Thank you for spending some time with this afternoon's edition.*

*Below this point are six more works of speculative, experimental, short, and flash fiction, three pieces about hybrid writing and the work behind short fiction, and three special recommendations from the back shelf.*

✓ Subscribed

*Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.*

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## More From the Discovery Desk

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### Congratulations on your Magic Sword™ - John Wiswell

Congratulations! You have a magic sword... but the sword also appears to have something resembling a user manual.

John Wiswell places the language of enchanted weapons and heroic quests beside instructions, warnings, and the sort of help given to someone using a complicated product for the first time.

Read “Congratulations on your Magic Sword™” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

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## **Her Name Will be Eleanor - Frank Sikora**

A clerk tells Gus the name of the woman who will become his wife, and what their life together is expected to look like.

The offer gives Gus considerably more information about his future than most people ever receive before making a decision.

Read “Her Name Will be Eleanor” at [365tomorrows](#)

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## **The Land - Susmita Ramani**

Laura and Herb have spent most of their lives together. Now Herb is dying and there is another option. His consciousness can be uploaded to a place called The Land.

Herb sees the possibility of continuing yet Laura is less certain that continuing forever is something she wants. The technology may be new, but the disagreement between them is much older...

Read “The Land” at [365tomorrows](#)

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## **They Named the Streets for Virtues So Girls Had Nowhere Else to Go - Jessica Roeder**

A tunnel bus uphill leads to a race back down the hill.

Jessica Roeder builds divisions into streets, hills, buses, neighbourhoods, and the games the girls make inside them. The differences in their world become clear without needing much explanation because the girls have already learned how to move through them.

Read “They Named the Streets for Virtues So Girls Had Nowhere Else to Go” at [JMWW](#)

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## **The New Neighborhood - R. J. Erbacher**

The new house is not finished yet. There are exposed wires, factory film still covering the windows, and neighbouring homes that have already burned or been destroyed.

R. J. Erbacher places a couple inside the remains of a familiar suburban future while the world outside no longer seems interested in following the same plan.

Read “The New Neighborhood” at [365tomorrows](#)

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## **The Cane and His Old Man - Victor McConnell**

An old man has left his cane underneath a restaurant table, and the cane is waiting for him to come back.

Victor McConnell gives the object its own voice, along with years of memories. This story is a stark reminder of how being forgotten feels very different from the perspective of the one that remembers.

Read “The Cane and His Old Man” at [Short Beasts](#)

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# Beyond the First Shelf

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## Introduction: A Genre of Losers - Jacob Baugher

Noir and hard-boiled detective fiction are often treated as the same thing, but Jacob Baugher begins with the difference between them.

His introduction to *Flash Fiction Online's* paranormal noir issue looks at noir's damaged characters and fatalism before explaining what happens when those ideas are mixed with horror, fantasy, and science fiction.

It also offers some useful context for "A Face Slipped Off Its Skull" and the other stories collected around it.

Read "Introduction: A Genre of Losers" at [Flash Fiction Online](#)

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## Interview: Heidi Czerwiec and Lee Horikoshi Roripaugh

Heidi Czerwiec and Lee Horikoshi Roripaugh talk with CRAFT about lyric essays and the space between familiar literary forms.

The conversation moves through fragments, white space, sound, research, visual elements, speculative nonfiction, and other ways an essay can change shape without losing what makes it an essay.

For anyone interested in hybrid work, it gives a wider look at how writers use form as part of what they are trying to say.

Read the interview at [CRAFT](#)

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## Meet Our Submissions Editors: Gillian O'Shaughnessy

What makes an editor stop at one story?

Gillian O'Shaughnessy talks about reading submissions for SmokeLong Quarterly, what makes a story stand out, and the importance of reading widely before sending work of your own.

It is a short conversation, but an interesting look at the first person on the other side of the submissions queue.

[Read the conversation at SmokeLong Quarterly](#)

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## Special Recommendations

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### The Machine Stops - E. M. Forster

Vashti lives underground in a room where nearly everything she needs is provided by the Machine. People can speak, listen to lectures, hear music, exchange ideas, and spend their lives without needing much direct contact with the world outside. Her son, Kuno, is not nearly as comfortable with that arrangement. More than a century after it was written the familiar parts of Forster's imagined world remain as interesting as the strange ones.

[Read "The Machine Stops" free through Project Gutenberg](#)

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## The Ones Who Stay and Fight - N. K. Jemisin

Um-Helat is a beautiful city built around the belief that people can deliberately make something better, and N. K. Jemisin does not leave it untouched.

The story speaks directly to the reader while moving through the city and the choices required to preserve what its people have created. It sits somewhere between fiction, argument, and an invitation to keep questioning the world being described.

Read “The Ones Who Stay and Fight” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

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## They’re Made Out of Meat - Terry Bisson

Two intelligent beings are discussing a newly discovered species. Unfortunately the species is made of meat...

The entire story unfolds through their conversation as they try to understand how something made from flesh could think, build machines, communicate, and consider itself intelligent.

It is short, very funny, and beyond fascinating.

Read “They’re Made Out of Meat” at [SETI.net](#)

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*Thank you for spending part of your day among the letters with us.*

*Today’s shelf moves through an orange, borrowed faces, alternate realities, chickens, a broken phone, a magic sword, a forgotten cane, and several different ideas of what a human life is supposed to look like.*

*A few pages are more than enough for great ideas.*

*Take care!*

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